Cathy Kaiqi Zhang

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Education

Washington University in St Louis
Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences
Advisor: Dr. Wouter Kool

PhD in Psychology, Behavior, Brain and Cognition track — now ABD, expected May 2027
Graduate Certificate of Quantitative Data Analysis
Dissertation: Learning what matters: Incentive effects on goal inference and information prioritization

M.A. Psychology — 2024
Master Thesis: Inferring mind wandering from perceptual decision making

University of California San Diego — 2021
B.S. Applied Math and B.S. Cognitive Science Spec. Neuroscience
Thesis advisor: Dr. Anastasia Kiyonaga
Honors Thesis: The effect of priority state of working memory content on its vulnerability to interference

Honors & awards

Psychonomic Society Graduate Travel Award	2026
Outstanding Assistance to Instruction nomination (Washington University in St Louis)	2026
Department Research Award (Washington University in St Louis)	2025
Outstanding Assistance to Instruction nomination (Washington University in St Louis)	2025
Dean's Undergraduate Award for Excellence (UC San Diego)	2021
Summa cum laude (UC San Diego)	2021

Publications

Zhang, C., & Kool, W. (2026). Inferring mind wandering from perceptual decision making. *Communications Psychology*.

Welhaf, M. S., **Zhang, C.**, Valdez, M. R., Kool, W., & Bugg, J. M. (2026). Are the correlates of mind wandering consistent across younger and older adults? *Psychological Research.*

Conference presentations

Zhang, C., Karagoz, B. A. & Kool, W. (2026) *Learning what matters: Goal certainty shapes working memory prioritization.* Poster to be presented at Psychonomic Society Annual Meeting. San Diego, CA, November 2026.

Zhang, C., & Kool, W. (2026) *Inferring Mind Wandering from Perceptual Decision Making.* Talk presented at Show-Me Mental State Conference. University of Missouri, MO, May 2026.

Wang, X.*, **Zhang, C.**, & Kool, W. (2026) *Impact of cognitive load on the effects of mind wandering*. Poster presented at Washington University Undergraduate Research Symposium. St Louis, MO, April 2026.

*denotes undergraduate co-author

Welhaf, M. S., **Zhang, C.**, Valdez, M. R., Kool, W., & Bugg, J. M. (2025). *A comprehensive investigation of potential mediators of age-related differences in mind wandering.* Poster presented at the Psychonomic Society Annual Meeting. Denver, CO, November 2025.

Zhang, C., & Kool, W. (2023) *Inferring Mind Wandering from Perceptual Decision Making.* Poster presented at Psychonomic Society Annual Meeting. San Francisco, CA, November 2023.

Invited talks & presentations

Shenhav Lab, University of California Berkeley (PI: Amitai Shenhav), 2024

Research group for Cognitive Neuroscience, The Arctic University of Norway (PI: Matthias Mittner), 2025

Krajbich Lab, University of California Los Angeles (PI: Ian Krajbich), 2026

Reviewing

Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory, and Cognition, Society of Cognitive Science

Teaching

Instructor, Washington University in St Louis

PSYCH 3600 Cognitive Psychology	Summer 2025, Summer 2026
PSYCH 1100 First-Year Opportunity: Contemporary Issues in Psychology	Fall 2026

Teaching Assistant, Washington University in St Louis

PSYCH 4631/5631 Introduction to Computational Cognitive Science	Spring 2024, Spring 2025
PSYCH 3600 Cognitive Psychology	Fall 2024, Fall 2025
PSYCH 3604 Cognitive Neuroscience	Fall 2023

Teaching Assistant, UC San Diego

COGS 17 Neurobiology of Cognition	Winter 2019
MATH 18 Linear Algebra	Winter 2019, Winter 2020
MATH 10A Calculus I	Fall 2019, Spring 2020

Mentoring

Xintian Wang (now PhD student in Washington University in St Louis Neuroscience Program)
Undergraduate honor thesis: Effect of cognitive load on mind wandering
Washington University in St Louis ENDURE grant ($7000)

Leyla Vilic (now master's student in Washington University in St Louis Olin Business School)

Service

Psychology Graduate Student Association: Social Committee Chair	2023-2024
St Louis Science Neuroscience Outreach: SciFest volunteer	2023
School of Arts & Sciences Gradchat panelist	2026